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GOD OF WAR II

When you've conquered Olympus and become a God—complete with castle in the skies—what else is left? Why, taking over the Heavens, of course. *God of War 2* (*GOW2*) continues the story of Kratos, the hard-nosed Spartan who, the last time we saw him, had worked his way up and defeated Ares to become the new God of War. Unfortunately, Zeus doesn't appreciate Kratos' designs on his throne, and betrays him into becoming a mortal again. Kratos must now seek the Sisters of Fate, and exact his vengeance upon Zeus. It's no modern classic, but *GOW2*'s story is still one of the most entertaining we've seen—hate, vengeance, divine politics and blood. Lots of blood.

I am, I must admit, one of those Unfortunate Souls who haven't experienced the original *God of War*. That said, the sequel makes no assumptions—you're still trained to learn Kratos' various moves and abilities, and right at the beginning of the game, you get to use all of his godly powers—only to have them stolen from you by Zeus, of course. You also don't need to know too much of the story—just the bit that you read in the first paragraph.

Where other action / adventure games are content with starting small, *GOW2* throws you into the action right away, and you get to face off with the first boss—the Colossus of Rhodes—rather quickly. The action varies between intense and insanely frenzied, and is gloriously gory and brutal. You'll also have to work through a few puzzles, but they aren't too tough and don't get on your nerves the way they do in so many such titles.

It's not just the action that's amazing—what takes you in with *GOW2* is how *big* everything is. The environments are expansive, ranging from the insides of huge statues to having to command a fleet of horses the size of Everest. Most of the bosses are insanely huge—as are the battles with them—and the satisfaction of watching something 3894529345234 times your size crumble at your feet can't be described in words.

God of War 2 takes the first ever 10/10 I've dished out—it's hard to find a flaw with this game! While many in the genre are competent, this was the only one that didn't keep me running around aimlessly for ten minutes trying to figure out what to do next. The graphics and soundtrack are brilliant and load astonishingly fast on the PS2—even saving a game isn't the torturous experience it's become in other PS2 titles. The action is more fun than you could imagine, and even the fixed camera angle doesn't get in the way of enjoyment. PS2 owners, take note—if you don't play this game, you'll be missing the best thing to happen to the PS2. Ever.

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Rating: 10/10
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